The State Department believed that it was neither feasible nor desirable to get into a "sales competition" with the Soviet Union. The Pentagon's concern increased, however, when it received reports that an Indian defense team had gone to Moscow. The Joint Chiefs of Staff worried that a Soviet foot in the military sales door would lead to a lot more because Moscow could undercut Washington on price and prove itself a reliable supplier to India. They recommended making an offer to support India's indigenous defense industry even if the US had to absorb some of the costs. In any case, they argued, these costs would be less than if the US were giving India military grants, which Delhi did not want anyway, or if Washington got into a sales race with Moscow. India had already expressed some interest in such assistance in talks with American defense corporations. The proposal also had the benefit of decreasing India's external dependence, assisting its economic development, conserving its foreign exchange, and maintaining the Western orientation of the Indian military. Overall, it was a more "permanent cure."[150]

This defense department proposal—as well as one for the near-term sale of helicopters—however, languished in the transition period between the Eisenhower and Kennedy administrations.[151]

The Camelot Years (1961–1962)

The Kennedy years have taken on a mythical quality; so have US-India relations during that period. The latter is in no small part due to the two countries' cooperation during the Sino-Indian War of 1962. That collaboration, however, was only possible because of what came before.

The "Present Excellent Trends"

Many of the strategic trends evident in Eisenhower's second term intensified in the Kennedy administration—including the emphasis on the nonaligned world and the need to fight indirect aggression. There was a change in tactics, which proved important for India since the incoming administration placed relatively less emphasis on military assistance and establishing formal alliances. It also helped that the new American president was "most interested" in India, as his speechwriter Arthur Schlesinger put it.[152]